



Asia Daily

Relief aid allowed into war region

NAIROBI: Sudan's government and rebels agreed yesterday to allow relief aid to move freely by road, water and air to the southern Sudan area battered by nearly 11 years of civil war.

In an agreement signed at the foreign ministry in Nairobi

by Manohar Espisu

after three days of peace talks, the Sudanese government and two rebel delegations said they also agreed to the principle of aid delivery to all needy people regardless of their location.

"It's fantastic," said Philip

O'Brien, the head of Operation Lifeline Sudan, the umbrella organisation providing aid to hundreds of thousands of people displaced by fighting in the south.

Aid workers said if the parties to the conflict in the south allowed the free movement of aid into the south by road from

Uganda and Kenya then it would make a substantial difference as agencies could stop the costly delivery of food by aircraft.

But they added that previous rounds of peace talks had come up with similar agreements to allow relief aid to move freely.

The next session of the peace

talks, mediated by Kenya, Uganda, Eritrea and Ethiopia, will be held on May 16 in Nairobi.

The negotiations, launched last week in the Kenyan capital, are the fifth since 1989 to end the war pitting the Arab and mainly Muslim north against the Christian and African south.

LEICESTER MERCURY, THURSDAY, MARCH 24, 1994 37 A

Talks set to resume

CAIRO: An Israeli team arrived in Cairo for talks with the PLO yesterday on protecting Palestinians in the occupied territories and restarting the peace process suspended since the Hebron massacre.

The Israeli officials are expected to give Palestinian negotiators their government's response to demands on security in the territories, made by the PLO during two days of talks in Tunis. The two sides have been searching for a way to resume talks on Palestinian self-rule, suspended over the Hebron massacre.

COUNTY DIGEST

Leaders back plea for new station

COMMUNITY leaders today expressed concern that firefighters from three stations have to be scrambled simultaneously to make sure at least one crew makes it to emergency scenes in the south of the city.

Councillors, community association bosses and a school headteacher all said they were worried at the situation.

A campaign to get a new southern station built was gathering momentum - and has won support from the county's chief ambulance officer, Mr Alan Parker.

Firefighters

The latest revelation comes hard on the heels of the news that firefighters arrive late at half the incidents they are called to in the Narborough, Blaby and Enderby areas.

Narborough Parish Council chairman John Cooper said: "A new station is a necessity. Otherwise we could have a disaster on our hands."

Councillor Cooper said road and rail accidents as well as fires could lead to a major tragedy if firefighters could not get to the scene in time.

He said: "This is a highly populated area and is getting busier. It's vital we have proper emergency cover."

A PA win would improve the SLFP's chances of returning to national power for the first time since 1977 in December's presidential voting and parliamentary polls early next year, analysts said.

Yesterday the top draws of Sri Lanka's ruling party and the opposition alliance scoured the grassroots for votes.

"The poll is crucial to both sides and a win to either side could set the trend for the next election," one analyst noted.

PA campaign chief Chandrika Kumaratunga, daughter of SLFP leader Sirima Bandaranaike, told Reuters the opposition would win because people were fed up with 17 years of unbroken UNP rule ridden with corruption, abuse of power and thuggery.

Rallies

Kumaratunga crisscrossed the southern landscape addressing between 20 to 30 small village rallies a day.

For the ruling UNP, Prime Minister Ranil Wickremesinghe relied on a US-style campaign, stumping across the region in a bus. President Dingiri Banda Wijetunga also canvassed.

UNP supporters said the government's progress in economic and social development would ensure victory.

"The government has done a lot, so they must win," said supporter K Dissanayake.

Opposition camp members disagreed.

Nations of Third World seek ban on waste

GENEVA: Third World nations said yesterday they would press for - and expected to win - a total ban on the export of toxic waste from rich to poor countries.

They made the announcement midway through a five-day meeting of the 64 signatory states to the 1990 Basle Convention, at which Denmark clashed with the European Union over the scope of future toxic waste export restrictions.

The convention, which came into force in 1992, calls for its parties to handle their own toxic waste as much as possible, but does not specifically rule out waste shipments. Sri Lankan environmental official Devanasa Nesiiah, representing the G77 group of developing nations, told the meeting the group would ask for a decision on its long-standing proposal for a total ban on waste shipments.

"We are confident that we have passed the critical tipping point and are on the verge of taking a momentous decision, among the most important in the history of the Basle Convention and in global environmental protection," Nesiiah told the meeting.

Decisions

Although such decisions are normally taken by consensus, Nesiiah said G77 nations were willing to force a vote on the resolution. "We have no doubt we would carry it," he said.

With many of the signatory states represented at ministerial level for the day, Danish Environment Minister Svend Auken spoke in support of a Danish proposal for a watertight ban on the export of toxic waste from developed to developing nations by the end of 1996.

A few minutes later, however, a European Union official proposed that exports of waste for final disposal should be banned but not exports for recycling. Under the EU resolution, a list would be established of those developing countries still willing to accept waste.

Voting peaceful in vital Sri Lanka regional poll

by Rohan Gunasekera

STARS GATHER FOR FILM PREMIERE



FIRST NIGHT: Left to right, Shashi Kapoor, Sally Field, Imran Khan, Goldie Hawn and director Ismail Merchant at a press conference held in Bombay after the premiere launch of Merchant's new film *Muhabbat* (In Custody)

Consensus candidate agreed

BLANTYRE: Four opposition parties formed a united front yesterday to back a single presidential candidate in Malawi's first multi-party elections in May.

Businessman Bakili Muluzi, chairman of the largest group in the alliance, the United Democratic Front, will be their challenger to veteran President Kamuzu Banda, a senior UDP official told Reuters.

Banda's grip on power has weakened since a referendum in last June when the country's 8.7 million people voted overwhelmingly to end his autocratic one-party rule.

The other parties in the new alliance are the United Front for Multi-Party Democracy, the Congress for the Second Republic and the Malawi Democratic Union.

"We will be presenting one presi-

dential candidate and we are negotiating to present suitably-agreed popular candidates for each of the constituencies that will be at stake in the general election," Justin Malewezi, the UDP's second vice-president, told Reuters.

Muluzi, a Muslim from southern Malawi and was regarded as a possible successor to Banda until he was sacked in disgrace in the early 1980s.

Food security is an indicator of whether a person has enough food to lead a healthy life, FAO Director Jacques Diouf called for more action to boost food production in worst-hit areas.

The FAO said that 45 countries had a low, or critically low, levels of food security.

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ASIA DAILY INFORMATION

Gold

LONDON GOLD FIXING: Gold was fixed at 390.30 dollars an ounce, equivalent to 59.403 per gramme (plus VAT for 22 ct gold).

Sunset Times

Sunset tonight: 6.20pm.
Sunrise time tomorrow: 5.51am.

Exchange Rates

Following are the current rates of exchange to one pound sterling:
India: 2.148 per 100 Rs
(Rs 46.55 per £1)
Pakistan: 45.20 Rs
Sri Lanka: 72.50 Rs

Bangladesh: 58.79 Taka
Kenya: 97.10 Shillings
Rates supplied by Midland Bank Plc International Banking Centre, 31 Granby Street, Leicester. Bangladesh rate by Bengali Community Education Project, 1 St Stephens Road, Highfields, Leicester.

Helplines

ISLAMIC Studies Centre: c/o 24 Wilson Street, Leicester, LE2 0BB. Tel: L. 511833/27063. This is an Islamic educational centre, supplementary school - community welfare on issues concerning the Muslim community. A mosques establishment.
LEICESTER Anti-Apartheid Movement: 8 Stoughton Drive North, Leicester LE5 5UB. Tel: L. 737790. The movement campaigns for the isolation of the South African regime and the end of apartheid.

Food shortage hits countries

ROME: Some 45 countries, two thirds of them in Africa, do not have enough food to ensure that their people can lead a healthy life, the UN Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO) has said.

An FAO report said that overall levels of food security in three quarters of the developing world had declined in the past year, often because of civil strife or its aftermath.

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